'da Kink in my Hair

By Trey Anthony

NOVELETTE: **(Pg 3)** *(addresses the audience while she readies her hairdressing shop for the day)* My work is never done! I'm always working, working, working. You want me to talk to you, explain what's going on? I have no time to talk to you today! I'm a busy busy career woman. *(She grabs a broom and begins sweeping)* I'm telling you between doing my makeup, sweeping, and of course doing hair, the work never stops! Being a hairdresser is not an easy thing. People rushing in here talking about oh Novelette, I want this style, this cut, this washed, this coloured, don't they see I'm busy – **(Pg 4)** I'm telling you if it's not one thing it's the other. Women rushing in here, looking like they got run over by a Mac truck, then expecting me to make them look like Janet Jackson. I said *(to a customer who sits in her chair)* lady I'm a hairdresser not a magician! **(Pg 12)** And don't you dare come back in here again looking like Donald Trump! *(begins to wash, cut and style her customer as she returns to her conversation with the audience)* I tell you as a hairdresser you get to know everybody's business. **(Pg 5)** Not that I'm nosy or anything. But if they don't tell you the hair will. Don't believe me? Well let me tell you . . my mother was a hairdresser, my mother's mother was a hairdresser , and my granny granny *(She counts on her fingers)* granny, branny use to b a hairdresser. If you want to know about a woman, a black woman, that is. Touch her hair Cause our hair carries our journey. 'Cause that's where we carry all our hopes, all our dreams, our hurts, our disappointments. They're

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all in our hair. *(She shakes her head)* You don't believe me well watch this! *(She begins to weave her fingers through her customer's hair. The hair sends her a message. She closes her eyes, her fingers entwined deeply in the woman's hair)* **(pg 6-7)** I'm telling you the hair sends me a message. Some of the things it tells me makes me want to laugh, makes me want to cry. And some of the things it tells me I don't even want to know. Because some of us are hurting. Hurting real bad. And you know as women we cry, cry a lot. Cry on the inside too proud to cry on the outside. And some of the thing, which the ahair tells me maks me want to cry. But I don't I keep it up here *(touches her head)* Right here in my head. Right here in my hair. . . .

INTRODUCTION

According to George Yancy, author of Our Black Sons Matter . . . "There are millions of loving mothers of Black sons who are painfully aware of what it means to give birth to and raise [them] in a world that marks their sons from birth as "unwanted," as "problems," who are already so-called criminals, uneducable thugs and surplus bodies.

The future for many young black males in America is not bright. They face a greater rate of imprisonment, a greater chance of being killed and a greater chance of being unemployed. Trey Anthony explores the emotional struggles of a mother trying her best to raise a black son in 'da Kink in My Hair.

NOVELETTE: **(Pg 17)** Lord, Patsy, I didn't think you were coming again. What time you running on West Indian or Christian time? *(She ushers Patsy into the chair)*

PATSY: *(She shakes her head obviously amused)* Sorry, Letty, prayer meeting ran over and you know you cannot rush the Lord.

NOVELETTE: *(She laughs gently)* Well, I am glad you made it. You know I've been meaning to come over and have a little tea or a strong drink of rum with you.

PATSY: Oh the Lord knows I'm going to pray for you darling.

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NOVELETTE: **(Pg 18)** Well while you're praying. You think you could ask the man up above about the Lotto numbers for me! Because I want to win some money!

PATSY: **(Pg 19-23)** Novelette! Please. Could you just give me the same thing like every week. A nice wash and set. A simple uptwist, with three hairpins thanks. *(Novelette touches Patsy's hair. As her fingers root themselves deeply into Patsy's hair, a preacher's voice is heard in the distance)*

PATSY as PREACHER: And the Lord says who shall believe in me will receive salvation.

PATSY: Romey use to say "Mom you worry too much. Ain't nothing ever gonna happen to me. "And then he would smile that easy slow smile that crept across his beautiful face. And those eyes, eyes full of mischief. Eyes that always let me know that child was up to something. *(beat)* Like taking four cookies instead of two. Changing that C minus on his report card to some messed up looking A. But he was a good kid. Yes he was. *(beat)*

I would say Jerome. I would call him Jerome when I get serious or I got something important to say. Otherwise he was just Romey, my Romey. And I remember that night, I said, Jerome I don't have a good feeling about this. Why don't you and Damion rent some movies and I'll fix you some Kool-aid, order some pizza and you boys just can stay in. The streets are not safe for young boys. *(beat)* And Romey rolled his eyes and smiled that easy slow smile. And he said "Mom, you worry too much, nothing going to happen to me. And besides Mom, we ain't on the streets it's a school dance. Nothing going to happen at a school dance. And Mom you know Denna Stewart going to be there, and you know I got a thing for Denna Stewart. I 'm gonna show her my moves on the dance hall and she's gonna be all mine." *(She laughs.)* And before I know it Damion's at the door, honking the horn. And Romey' s racing down the front step. And I said *(very urgent)* "Jerome! Be careful." And he smiled that easy slow

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smile. And he said "I'll be home by twelve-thirty" and I said "you better be in here by twelve a.m." and he took off running. And we both knew he wouldn't be home till twelve-forty-five. That's Romey always trying to get away with something. But he was a good kid. My boy was good. And that's all I said "be home by twelve." And he was gone. *(beat, emotion begins to build, voice wavers)* And I'm real mad with myself. Cause I thought I should have told him wear your brown coat cause it's a real warm coat. But I let him leave wearing the blue one and that not a real warm coat. And I should have told him I loved him-*(yells out)* I love you! And I should have just listened to that rotting feeling in my gut and begged him to stay. *(yells out)* Stay home Romey! But I didn't. I should have just said *(yells)* Wear your brown coat Romey, it's a warmer coat! Because he was lying on the ground you know, on the cold hard ground. Bleeding to death. And maybe if he was just wearing his brown coat-maybe the coat would have kept him-maybe ... But brown coats don't protect little black boys from bullets do they. Damion said they were outside in the school parking lot. Romey was talking to Denna. And one minute he was laughing, and there was a bang and Romey fell to the ground. *(two beats)*

No one knows who did it. No one knows why. And no one is talking about it. There was no witnesses. No witnesses? Nearly two hundred kids in a parking lot and no one saw anything. But someone shot Romey three times. Three times and my baby's gone. Because they killed him! They can do that! Your son can kill my son just because! Because, maybe he didn't like the color of his jacket. They are killing each other! *(two beats)* And the police claim they are doing all that they can. But who is protecting our children from some of them police. How much is my son's life worth? *(beat)* Why do you need a license to shoot a damn bird! You go to jail for leaving your dog outside! But my baby, can lie on the ground for

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twenty minutes before someone calls an ambulance. *(beat)* Because there is no sign posted "warning Black boys are in danger of becoming extinct." How come they can't grow up to be Black men? *(three beats)* And I know as a mother, you're suppose to love them, teach them, keep their butts in line, tell them to wear brown coats instead of blue-but you're not suppose to bury them! *(beat)* A mother isn't supposed to bury her son ... *(three beats)*

I took my ultrasound yesterday. And it's a boy. Me a mother again? And I thought about you Romey. Maybe he'll have your slow moving easy smile. Or maybe he'll have your eyes. Eyes full of mischief. And I cried. Cried for my baby. Right there in the waiting room I bawled, nose running and everything, a real ugly kinna cry. I cried for my sons. Cried for our sons. (two beats) And all the other mothers in the waiting room, they just looked away. Just looked away. Cause they understood. *(beat)* No, they understand.

(PATSY returns back to the chair and the lights change. NOVELETTE's hands are still in her hair and has told her the story. Novelette speak softly, gently with this new knowledge)

NOVELETTE: So there you go a nice wash and set. This hair is growing, nice and thick. You know, they say a woman's hair grows when she's pregnant.

PATSY: Letty, how did you know? I haven't told anyone but my husband and God .

NOVELETTE: I know.

PATSY: Oh, Letty, I don't know if I can do this again. You know with Romey and everything ... and what if I'm not a good mother and maybe it's too soon. And and-- I just can't help thinking about Romey and if I had only ... *(sighs)* and maybe I'm too old. Novelette you think I'm too old?

NOVELETTE: Patsy, you're not too old! And I'm no Christian or anything, but I believe God knew you had a lot more love to give so he decided to give you another chance. I knew Romey and that boy was a good kid. And good kids don't raise

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themselves Patsy. You were [and will be] a good mother. *(To audience)* **(Pg 5)** You want to know about a woman, a black woman that is. Touch her hair. That's where we carry all our hopes, all our dream, our hurts, our disappointments. [It's] 'da kink in our hair.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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